Trains could ply only by night; consequently, the progress was slow. Bose would, of course, visit his troops at stations where the trains halted, to look after their welfare and progress. The troop trains were bound for Bangkok. Bose reached Bangkok on 15 May and his troops arranged for the reception of Indian stragglers (refugees) from Burma because of the worsening conditions of the war there. [124]

HOW AN ALERT TRAIN DRIVER SAVED GANDHIJI'S LIFE

It is a little known fact that there was a possible conspiracy to assasinate Gandhiji by derailing a train. Various records state that there were five to six attempts to assassinate Mahatma Gandhi since 1934. One of them was eighteen months before his death, when a train that he was travelling in was attempted to be derailed. An alert train driver had stopped it in time, saving Gandhiji's life.

On 29 June 1946, Gandhiji was travelling by train to Pune from Bombay and there was a huge pile of debris on the railway track between the Neral and Karjat stations, with the intention of killing Gandhiji in an accident. However, the accident was averted because of the alertness of a motorman, M.L. Pareira. Yet, the railway engine was severely damaged. Pyarelal Nayyar, Gandhiji's personal secretary, wrote an article in the 7 July 1946 edition of *Harijan* on this incident. He writes:

> The railway train which carried Mahatma Gandhi collided with the heaps of debris piled up across the railway track on the night of 29 June, when the said special train was in full speed. The said debris were deliberately piled up across the track. The accident was averted only because of the alertness of the engine driver. Otherwise, there would have been damage to the life of Gandhiji and others because of the accident. Since the train was the only one scheduled at that time, it seems likely that the intended target of derailment was Gandhi himself. He was not injured in the accident. At a prayer meeting after the event Gandhi is quoted as saying, 'I have not hurt anybody, nor do I consider anybody to be my enemy. I can't understand why there are so many attempts on my life. Yesterday's attempt on my life has failed. I will not die just yet; I aim to live till the age of 125.' [125]

Sadly, he had only eighteen more months to live .

THIRD CLASS COACH FOR GANDHIJI'S FUNERAL

> As in life, so in death. The last journey of the Mahatma was also in a third class rail carriage. Throughout his life, Gandhiji never preferred to travel in any other class other